

Covering Ears to Steal a Bell

掩耳盗铃

A thief wanted to steal a very valuable and large bell, so he decided to smash it so that he could carry it home. But when he hit it, the loud clang surprised him and he covered his ears, thereby muffling the sound. He decided to use cloth to plug his ears, foolishly thinking it quieted the bell so that he could hit it repeatedly. Neighbors soon heard the sound and caught the thief in the act.

One gourd is pushed under the water, but another floats up.

按下葫芦起了瓢

Too many problems pop up one after another and prove to be too much to cope with.

You can't expect to catch a cub without venturing into a tigress's den.

不入虎穴焉得虎子

Risky as it is, if you are afraid of taking chances, there is no way you can succeed.

Hidden dragons, crouching tigers.

藏龙卧虎;

When you say some place has "hidden dragons and crouching tigers" you mean that that place has able people who are kept willingly or unwillingly in a low profile. The proverb is usually used to advise people not to take a place like that lightly.

A foot is short, an inch is long.

尺短寸长

Compared with something longer, a feet may be shorter; compared with something shorter, an inch seems longer. Things are relative: everything has its merits and demerits.

Forget the fishing gear as soon as the fish is caught.

得鱼忘筌

Forget the means by which the end is attained.

Turn stone/iron into gold by the touch.

点石成金

To say one can turn iron into gold by the touch is to describe him as having superb skills that can turn a mediocre work into a masterpiece.

Lure a tiger down its mountain.

调虎离山

Lure an enemy out of its well defended base to annihilate it.

Conjure up clouds with one turn of one's hand and rain with another. (or similar)

翻云覆雨

To say that someone can conjure up clouds and rain with his turn of hand is to say that he is capricious or skillful at playing tricks.

To be like neither a donkey nor a horse.

非驴非马

If something one has created is like neither animals, then it must be something awkward and laughable.

(As rare as) phoenix feather and unicorn horns.

凤毛麟角

According to Chinese legends, phoenix's feather and unicorn's horns are the rarest things one can find in the world.

Scratching an itch from outside the boot.

隔靴搔痒

To scratch one's itch with boots on is to attempt a very ineffective solution to a problem.

One palm makes no applause.

孤掌难鸣

This is an admonishment against both parties in a dispute: the dispute would be impossible without either party.

Fish swim in vast sea as freely as birds fly in boundless sky.

海阔凭鱼跃，天高任鸟飞

The English counterpart is "Imagination is your only limit." Go for it.

Draw a cake to satisfy one's hunger.

画饼充饥

An unrealistic solution to a problem serves no other purpose than self deception.

Fill in the eyes to a painted dragon. (Two drops of ink...)

画龙点睛

A finishing touch. It is said that a famous Chinese painter painted four dragons without eyes. When asked, he explained that with eyes they would fly away. Incredulous, his friends insisted on his filling in the eyes. Sure enough, as soon as the painter added eyes to two of the dragons, they started flying away. This proverb is most often used to describe a situation where one who uses succinct remarks to summarize the gist of an article or a speech.

Add legs to the snake one has just painted.

画蛇添足

Do something that is totally unnecessary and spoil what you already have done.

Swallow a date with its stone.

囫圇吞枣

When someone does this, he is said to read without understanding.

Fish in muddled water.

混水摸鱼

Take the advantage of a confused situation to make personal gains.

A tiger's (dragon's) head and a snake's tail.

虎头蛇尾

A good beginning with a lousy ending.

A frog in a well shaft

井底之蛙

A frog who lived in a well all his life never knew what the real body of waters was until a sea turtle told him about it. This proverb refers to somebody who has a very narrow-minded view of what they see or think.

A clay idol of bodhisattva fording a river can hardly save itself, let alone anyone else.

泥菩萨过河—自身难保

Such a savior made in clay could save nobody on the other side of a river as the water would soak and dissolve it. When one is in serious trouble, he may not be able to save his own tail, let alone others'.

Looking for a donkey on its very back.

骑驴找驴

Looking for something as if it were missing while it is just under one's nose.

Fish for the moon in the water.

水中捞月

It is a useless attempt. A folklore goes that a kingdom of monkeys seeing the reflection of the moon in a well thought it fell into it. They formed a monkey chain to fish it, only to find that the moon was still in the evening sky.

Crows everywhere are equally black.

天下乌鸦一般黑

It is a metaphorical statement of "Bad people are bad no matter where you find them because human nature never changes".

Dream different dreams on the same bed.

同床异梦

Hide different purposes behind the semblance of accord.

No wind, no waves.

无风不起浪

How about "*There is no fire without smoke.*"? The assumption here is that rumors may have some grounds.

An image of a bamboo has already been formed in mind before it is committed to the painting canvas.

胸有成竹 or 成竹在胸

One is certain about something to happen.

Send charcoal in a snow storm.

雪里送炭

Offer help when help is needed.

Add frost to snow.

雪上加霜

Add insult to injury.

A thief cries "Stop thief!"

贼喊捉贼

This is a ploy criminals often use to divert the attention of investigators.